Welcome to East Detroit

Reading 1 of 4: The city, its people and its neighborhoods in 2030

Public Mechanics
Student edition, November 2026

How to read this document

East Detroit is a fictional consolidated city and county in Colorado, east of Denver International Airport. The geography around it is real. The city, its statistics, its neighborhoods and its institutions are invented for this course.

Three labels mark the difference throughout these readings:

- **REAL REFERENCE:** a real place, law, organization or published figure. Sources are listed at the end.
- **SCENARIO:** a fact the course has created. Treat it as true inside the exercise.
- **OPEN:** a choice the class has not made. You and your classmates decide it.

Do not present scenario figures, such as East Detroit's population, neighborhoods or income levels, as real Census data or Colorado law.

The city in 2030

East Detroit is a newly consolidated Colorado city and county. Its growth resembles metropolitan Phoenix in scale and pattern: fast residential expansion, master-planned districts, warehousing and logistics, jobs arriving before public facilities, older settlements meeting new development, and wide differences in who benefits from growth. The course begins in 2030. You do not need to explain how the city reached its current size.

Table 1. East Detroit at a glance

Item	East Detroit in 2030 (SCENARIO)
Official name	City and County of East Detroit, Colorado
Population	382,417
Occupied households	155,800
Residents in group quarters	3,823
How the population is modeled	155,800 households × 2.43 residents + 3,823 in group quarters = 382,417
Study area	About 115.4 square miles, unsurveyed
Built-up area	About 25 square miles, averaging 15,297 people per square mile

Item	East Detroit in 2030 (SCENARIO)
Neighborhoods	20 provisional neighborhoods in 5 planning regions

The 115.4-square-mile study area is far larger than the built-up city. Much of it is employment land, farmland, aviation protection zones, infrastructure or undeveloped land. The study area is a working outline for mapping. It is not a claim about where any real jurisdiction's lines fall.

Founding condition. You may assume the constitutional and legislative steps needed to create the city-county have already happened. The city-county has not yet adopted an internal charter design, intergovernmental agreement, service platform or administrative structure for the exercise. Those are **OPEN**.

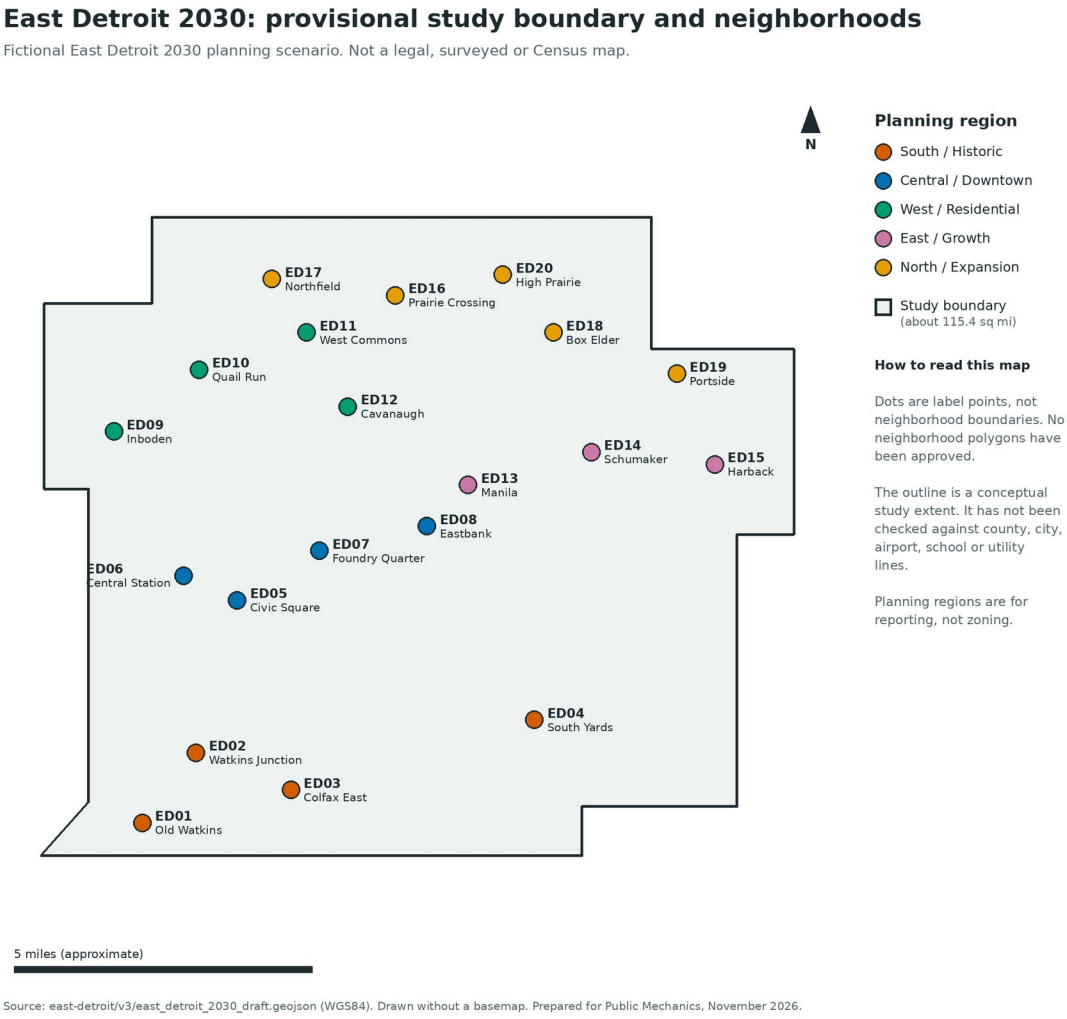


Figure 1. Provisional East Detroit study boundary with the 20 neighborhood label points, colored by planning region. The dots mark neighborhood names only; no neighborhood boundaries have been approved. The outline has not been checked against real county, city, airport, school or utility lines.

Where the city sits: the real geography

REAL REFERENCE. East Detroit is set around real places: Watkins, the Colorado Air and Space Port (airport code KCFO), Interstate 70, the Union Pacific rail corridor, Colfax Avenue, Box Elder Creek, and Denver International Airport to the west. The main existing postal code is Watkins 80137. Neighboring real postal codes may appear on reference maps. The course has not created any new ZIP codes; a city postal scheme for 2030 is **OPEN**.

Adams County's *Colorado Air and Space Port Subarea Plan* describes a 48-square-mile study area bounded by I-70, Hudson Road, E. 72nd Avenue and Harback Road. That area included 21,079 acres of unincorporated Adams County, 9,738 acres within Aurora, and 375 acres in Bennett. The plan identifies gaps in water and wastewater capacity and land-use conflicts near airport operations. These are real constraints the class must respond to, not problems the fictional city has already solved.

SCENARIO. East Detroit's study area includes the 48-square-mile spaceport planning area and extends north and east from it. Watkins remains the city's historic southeastern gateway. The larger area leaves room for a credible city without placing housing around the spaceport runway.

The real airfield, runway protection zones, stormwater channels, major roads and county and municipal lines limit what the city can build. The 2030 transit hubs, the light and heavy rail network, venue sites, district names and service locations are invented or proposed.

Who lives in East Detroit

All figures in Table 2 describe fictional East Detroit (**SCENARIO**). They are planning assumptions, not measurements of the real area. Population and household totals are in Table 1.

Table 2. Fictional socioeconomic profile of East Detroit, 2030

Indicator	East Detroit 2030
Households that rent	53.6%
Median household income, in 2024 dollars	$88,430
People below the poverty line	12.8%
Residents under 18	22.6%
Residents 65 and older	11.6%
Foreign-born residents	18.4%
Residents speaking another language at home	29.6%
Adults with a disability or long-term functional limitation	12.8%

Indicator	East Detroit 2030
People without health insurance	10.6%
Renters paying at least 30% of income for housing	49.8%
Median gross rent, in 2024 dollars	$1,865 per month
Non-Hispanic White	37.4%
Hispanic or Latino, any race	33.2%
Non-Hispanic Black	13.5%
Non-Hispanic Asian	7.8%
Non-Hispanic Indigenous	1.2%
Other or multiracial, non-Hispanic	6.9%

The race and ethnicity categories add to 100% so the simulation can use them as separate groups. Standard Census tables treat race and Hispanic origin differently. Check these categories against a real classification standard before building household-level data. No service design in this course should base eligibility decisions on these attributes.

REAL REFERENCE: how the scale was set. U.S. Census QuickFacts for Adams County (2020–2024) reports a median household income of $94,571 in 2024 dollars, median gross rent of $1,781, about 9.8% of people in poverty, 68.6% of housing owner-occupied, and 43.7% of residents Hispanic or Latino. The July 2025 estimate put Adams County at 554,668 residents. For the real Watkins census-designated place, the 2020–2024 American Community Survey estimates only 847 residents and a median household income of about $158,173. Estimates for an area that small are uncertain. None of these are East Detroit figures. East Detroit's income, housing and poverty assumptions were set to create several different kinds of access and affordability problems.

The twenty neighborhoods

Neighborhoods are communities, not zoning districts. Their names are provisional. Some come from local streets and landscape (Watkins, Inboden, Quail Run, Cavanaugh, Manila, Schumaker, Harback, Box Elder); others are new urban identities (Foundry Quarter, Civic Square, Central Station). Zoning and other rules are decided separately. **No neighborhood boundaries have been adopted.**

All figures in Table 3 are **SCENARIO** planning inputs. You may propose revisions through the class decision record.

Table 3. Neighborhood figures, 2030. Incomes are in 2024 dollars for comparison with the 2020–2024 American Community Survey. Rent-burdened renters are renter households paying at least 30% of income for housing.

ID	Neighborhood	Population	Households	Median household income	Renters	Rent-burdened renters
ED01	Old Watkins	10,158	4,180	$103,200	38%	35%
ED02	Watkins Junction	20,908	8,604	$71,600	66%	52%
ED03	Colfax East	18,289	7,526	$58,900	73%	61%
ED04	South Yards	12,271	5,050	$62,100	77%	58%
ED05	Civic Square	26,418	10,505	$92,400	62%	46%
ED06	Central Station	28,405	11,311	$89,700	75%	55%
ED07	Foundry Quarter	25,070	10,177	$74,500	71%	54%
ED08	Eastbank	21,115	8,615	$119,300	47%	37%
ED09	Inboden	15,507	6,381	$126,400	33%	28%
ED10	Quail Run	15,651	6,441	$95,600	46%	40%
ED11	West Commons	22,520	9,267	$84,700	52%	45%
ED12	Cavanaugh	16,726	6,883	$78,100	60%	52%
ED13	Manila	24,790	10,058	$112,600	39%	35%
ED14	Schumaker	17,407	7,163	$97,700	45%	43%
ED15	Harback	11,442	4,709	$86,500	53%	49%
ED16	Prairie Crossing	22,663	9,162	$107,900	43%	36%
ED17	Northfield	21,787	8,834	$134,800	29%	30%
ED18	Box Elder	18,676	7,686	$66,800	69%	58%
ED19	Portside	13,690	5,460	$76,700	62%	55%
ED20	High Prairie	18,924	7,788	$151,200	26%	25%

Do not average these rows to get citywide figures. The citywide median income was set separately; a citywide median cannot be calculated by averaging twenty neighborhood medians. Neighborhood renter and rent-burden shares also need weighting by household counts. Verifying the citywide figures would require household-level synthetic data.

What each neighborhood is like

For every neighborhood, city staff must test whether assistance, transportation and public information reach residents with different work schedules, housing arrangements and access to documents.

South / Historic

- **Old Watkins (ED01):** legacy village, small businesses, agricultural families, aging owners and renters.
- **Watkins Junction (ED02):** rail-adjacent mixed housing, service workers and newly arrived families.
- **Colfax East (ED03):** older commercial corridor, lower-cost apartments and frequent moves.
- **South Yards (ED04):** industrial jobs, truck access, worksite housing and pollution concerns.

Central / Downtown

- **Civic Square (ED05):** civic center, mixed-income midrise homes and demand for public services.
- **Central Station (ED06):** major transfer station, dense rental housing and night economy.
- **Foundry Quarter (ED07):** converted production sites, offices and relatively affordable family flats.
- **Eastbank (ED08):** riverside greenways, apartments and a growing professional population.

West / Residential

- **Inboden (ED09):** older subdivided homes, concentrated ownership and school access.
- **Quail Run (ED10):** townhomes, duplexes and childcare shortages.
- **West Commons (ED11):** family apartments, multifamily infill and school crowding.
- **Cavanaugh (ED12):** transit-adjacent apartments and wage-dependent households.

East / Growth

- **Manila (ED13):** large mixed-use blocks, newer homes and rapid infrastructure demands.
- **Schumaker (ED14):** working households near advanced logistics, with long commutes.
- **Harback (ED15):** small fringe settlements, wells, septic conversion and annexation disputes.

North / Expansion

- **Prairie Crossing (ED16):** new housing, high school enrollment and debates over transit expansion.
- **Northfield (ED17):** new ownership-focused development with uneven access to nearby services.
- **Box Elder (ED18):** flood-prone drainage crossings, renters and seasonal workers.
- **Portside (ED19):** edges of the employment district, shift work and airport noise.
- **High Prairie (ED20):** high-income new housing, large lots and infrastructure contributions.

What residents are dealing with

These are **SCENARIO** conditions. They are not rules, proposals or solved problems.

1. **Housing costs and instability.** Longtime homeowners and newer renters are in very different financial positions. South Yards and Colfax East have high shares of renters and severe cost

burdens. The city has not settled emergency rent assistance, tenant information, inclusionary housing or legal support.

2. **Mismatched addresses and records.** Older farm addresses, newly subdivided parcels and apartment complexes may not match across county mapping (GIS), postal delivery, tax rolls, utility accounts and school assignment systems. Having an account is not proof of residency.
3. **Water and land conversion.** A region that relies on groundwater, agricultural parcels, special districts and utility extensions cannot assume unlimited supply. Households, housing developers and industrial employers compete for service commitments. The real Adams County spaceport plan describes regional water and wastewater needs.
4. **Long distances.** Much of the city-county is low-density. The urban center has a rail hub in the scenario, but areas to the north and east have infrequent service, late-shift workers, and no settled transit partnership. The city cannot order the Regional Transportation District (RTD) to run a municipal route.
5. **Jobs without matching housing.** Logistics, manufacturing, entertainment, medical institutions, schools and services create varied shift schedules, pay levels, noise and labor demand. Not every household benefits from aerospace investment.
6. **Public authority and appeals.** Under Colorado's real structure, the county administers state-supervised benefits. The city-county must decide how new city services connect with those programs without taking over state eligibility rules.
7. **Health and emergency access.** The scenario includes a trauma center. Dispatch integration, patient information, 911, emergency access, public safety and hospital data are unsettled.
8. **Schools and young families.** Fast-changing enrollment, new attendance boundaries and school transportation create urgent demands. School districts are independent; their participation must be negotiated.
9. **Growth on farmland and floodplains.** Existing farmland, drainage corridors and protected airspace remain real constraints. Urbanization creates value for some and displacement risk for landowners, tenants, farmworkers and nearby communities.
10. **Participation and representation.** Neighborhoods differ in language access, income, housing tenure, commute and ability to attend evening meetings. A citywide digital vote or app may reproduce those differences instead of resolving them.

Civic and cultural anchors

These institutions are **SCENARIO** facts. Their existence does not decide funding, ownership, digital systems or service agreements, which remain **OPEN**.

- **The Hangar at Space Center:** a 17,500-seat arena at the central RTD rail hub. The hub's capital plan, fare rules, station management and shared-service responsibilities are open.
- **Denver Fawns (WNBA):** based at The Hangar.
- **Colorado Apex (PWHL):** plays at The Hangar.

- **Denver Pilots (Triple-A baseball):** relocated from Albuquerque in the scenario's sports history. They play at **Aerotropolis Park**, a 16,210-seat ballpark with views of active launches from the fictional 2030 KCFO.
- **East Detroit Philharmonic & Performing Arts Center (EDPAC):** 2,200 seats. A proposed 1% Public Art Commercial Fee is a financing question, not adopted tax law.
- **East Detroit Health System:** a Level I regional trauma center, aerospace flight medicine program and teaching hospital. Whether it joins a government emergency data exchange is open.

These teams, relocations, launches and facilities are fictional. They make no claim about real professional sports or about KCFO's actual spaceflight schedule.

Public institutions you will work with

SCENARIO. East Detroit has operating city and county departments and elected leaders. Some organizations that serve residents are independent of the city-county: school districts, RTD, water providers, airport owners and operators, state and federal agencies, and neighboring jurisdictions. They may agree to joint work, refuse it or set conditions.

Two housing institutions already exist and are separate:

- The **City and County of East Detroit Housing Division (EDHD)** is a city-county department. It handles city-funded housing policy, affordable housing development and preservation, local assistance and homelessness prevention.
- The **East Detroit Regional Housing Authority (EDRHA)** is an independent public housing authority with its own board. It serves the city and participating communities outside it.

Reading 2 explains how authority is divided. Reading 3 covers the two housing institutions and the real cases they are modeled on.

Six households to test services against

All six households are invented. They are not stereotypes or eligibility findings.

Table 4. Case households for class exercises

Case	Household and situation	Question for agencies
H01	Two adults and one child renting in Colfax East; one hourly worker's schedule changes weekly	Can they complete and correct an application without taking time off work?
H02	Retired homeowner in Old Watkins; the parcel has an older rural address and an unmatched new GIS record	Which office owns the correction, and who keeps a pending request open?
H03	Three-generation household in Box Elder; Spanish is the preferred service language	What is available in person, by phone and in translation?

Case	Household and situation	Question for agencies
H04	Transit-dependent shift worker in Portside; the employer's private shuttle stops before the final shift ends	What happens if RTD or the employer declines a service partnership?
H05	Single parent in West Commons with two children entering different schools	Can city services coordinate without claiming control over an independent school district?
H06	Small business owner in South Yards whose address and parcel records do not match	Who decides whether a permit proceeds while county GIS corrects the source record?

You can add cases, change details and argue about what they mean. Test every service against at least four kinds of case: a routine case, a disputed record, an outside partner that refuses to take part, and a case that needs human help or an appeal.

Sources

These real sources set the geographic and demographic scale. They do not describe East Detroit.

1. Adams County, *Colorado Air and Space Port Subarea Plan* (study-area map, p. 3; recommendations; utilities). https://adamscountyco.gov/wp-content/uploads/2025/08/space-port-subarea-plan.pdf
2. U.S. Census Bureau, QuickFacts: Adams County, Colorado (2020–2024 income, housing, race and rent; 2025 population). https://www.census.gov/quickfacts/fact/table/adamscountycolorado/PST045225
3. Census Reporter, Watkins CDP, Colorado (2020–2024 American Community Survey). https://censusreporter.org/profiles/16000US0882900-watkins-co/
4. Colorado Information Marketplace, DRCOG Municipal Boundaries (updated 2026). https://data.colorado.gov/Government/DRCOG-Municipal-Boundaries/xufp-56dv
5. Colorado Legislative Council, *Colorado Local Government Handbook* (city and county structure, school and special districts). https://content.leg.colorado.gov/sites/default/files/local_gov_hb_web.pdf